

[Return to Search](#)

Islam and clan organization among the Hausa

Author(S): Greenberg, Joseph Harold

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 204

Culture (OWC): [Hausa \(MS12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1938-1939

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Nigeria

Section Title(S)

THE INSTITUTION OF THE CLAN AMONG THE PAGAN HAUSA

In view of the widespread nature of slavery in former times, it is not improbable that new clans often arose in this manner. However, the mechanism of slave incorporation into pagan Hausa society employed just prior to the British occupation in the district of Jigawa, the one most intensively studied, would not lead to such results. The male slave was adopted by the compound head as a son, and he was thereafter reckoned as a member of the clan of his master. A wife was then obtained for him from another clan, his owner paying the bride-price. After his master's death he might establish a compound of his own and this household would, of course, be reckoned among those of his former master's clan.

[567
Slavery](#)

[618
Localized Kin Groups](#)

Clans between which the play relationship is found usually live at a fairly great distance from each other at the present time, but it is invariably stated that they formerly lived in close proximity to each other. In spite of the special relationship existing between such pairs of clans, there is no marked tendency for intermarriage to be appreciably more frequent than between other clans.

[567
Slavery](#)

[618
Localized Kin Groups](#)

The other joking relationships between individuals are between grandparents and grandchildren, between parents and their youngest child (who in this as in other respects is assimilated to a grandchild), between a man and his older sibling's spouse and a woman and her older sibling's spouse. Grandparents and grandchildren of opposite sex call each other "husband" and "wife" in play, and this is also true of brothers-in-law and sisters-in-law who are joking

[113
Bibliographies In
Sources](#)

[587
Secondary Marriages](#)

relatives. The latter are all potential mates by the junior levirate or junior sororate, institutions which exist among the Kare-Kare and other tribes of Northern Nigeria linguistically related to the Hausa and with similar kinship terminologies and patterns [205](#) of joking and respect relationships. ⁸ The recent presence of this type of marriage is attested by several older informants. Indeed, the levirate at least is found among the Moslem Hausa and its disappearance among the pagans studied may be a local phenomenon. One informant, in emulation of W. H. R. Rivers, deduced the former existence of the levirate and sororate from the custom just mentioned of the use of the terms "husband" and "wife" by those who were potential partners in such marriages.

[602](#)[Kin Relationships](#)[603](#)[Grandparents And Grandchildren](#)[607](#)[Siblings-In-Law](#)

These peoples include the Bolewa, Ngizim, Kare-kare, Ngamo, and Kanakuru, all of whom are treated in C. K. Meek, *Tribal Studies in Northern Nigeria* (2 vols., London, 1931), vol. 2.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)